

Also Remember...

- Some devices come with voice recording capability. This would allow you to use the player as a dictaphone.
- Built-in FM tuner is a useful feature on a long journey when you have had your fill of the songs stored in the player's memory.
- It is useful if the MP3 player can play back other file formats such as WMA.
- Make sure that you have the right port (parallel or USB) free on your PC.
- Encoding your music CDs into MP3s is a very CPU-intensive task. Make sure that you have a reasonably powerful processor (at least 400 MHz) on your PC. Otherwise it would take you quite a while to encode or transfer MP3s.

Shades of Music

When they first entered the Indian market, these devices were exorbitantly priced, but this scenario is changing. With the explosion in the number of such devices available abroad, a ripple effect is being seen here in the Indian markets, with prices dropping and greater variety available.

The most commonly available MP3 players are the solid-state devices with storage capacity beginning from 32 MB. There are two major Flash RAM standards in use today—Compact Flash and the newer Smart Media. Since memory is the most expensive component of an MP3 player, it has a major impact on the overall cost of the device. Popular brands in India include Creative and Diamond's Rio. The prices range from Rs 8,000 to Rs 25,000.



Technology Insight

Most devices use Flash RAM (minimum 32 MB) but some newer models can read MP3 CDs instead. A few products use a hard disk (6 GB for the Creative Jukebox) as their primary storage medium. Flash memory, however, completely eliminates skipping.

Smart Tips

LCD screen: A backlit display that allows you to view track and status information is very

useful. Most players have single or two-line displays but some (like the Lyra) feature a multi-line 16-character by 6-line dot matrix display capable of displaying ASCII characters.

Control and menu navigation keys: Similar to regular CD players, you have buttons for functions such as Play, Stop, Forward, Rewind, Search, Random, Programmable tracks, etc. Additional shortcut and navigation keys are a welcome addition.

Batteries: The digital signal processor forms the heart of the MP3 player and performs the task of decoding, processing and converting the MP3 data into audible audio format using a built-in codec.

File transfer Interface:

This is the medium for the transfer of MP3 files between the player and your PC. The most popular method is through a serial cable, which connects to your PC's parallel port. Newer devices use the hot-pluggable USB interface, which allows faster file transfers.

Memory expansion: You can buy add-on memory modules (Compact Flash cards or by Flash RAM) depending upon the standard supported by the device. Make sure that the player supports memory upgrades in case you decide you need it in the future.

Headphones: The headphones that come bundled with most MP3 players are usually of a low quality. If you are a music connoisseur you should look around for better-quality headphones from brands such as Sony, Sennheiser or Koss. Here again, make sure that you actually try out the headphones with the device before you actually put down the money for it.

	Easy listening	Music enthusiast
You need	Something you pick up while on the go	A player that you intend to live with and want your entire music collection accessible
Look for	A player that uses Flash RAM and has at least 64MB of memory with the option to upgrade	A player that uses either a hard-disk or CDs as the medium for storing music
Our pick	Apacer Audio Steno	Apple iPod
Price range	Up to Rs. 10,000	Up to Rs 30,000

